Common Sense

Thomas Paine · January 1776 · excerpts

Source: Thomas Paine, Common Sense (1776), text via Project Gutenberg (#147). Public domain; 1776 spelling retained.

Published anonymously in Philadelphia in January 1776, Thomas Paine's pamphlet sold an estimated 120,000 copies in three months — extraordinary for a colonial population of about 2.5 million. Paine argued in plain language that reconciliation with Britain was impossible and that monarchy itself was illegitimate. The pamphlet helped shift colonial opinion from protest to independence in the months before the Declaration.

Connect: How does Paine's attack on monarchy build on the colonists' grievances from Class 2?

Key Passages

On monarchy

> There is something exceedingly ridiculous in the composition of monarchy; it first excludes a man from the means of information, yet empowers him to act in cases where the highest judgment is required. … One of the strongest NATURAL proofs of the folly of hereditary right in kings, is, that nature disapproves it, otherwise she would not so frequently turn it into ridicule by giving mankind an ASS FOR A LION.

On reconciliation

> But Britain is the parent country, say some. Then the more shame upon her conduct. … Europe, and not England, is the parent country of America. … Every thing that is right or natural pleads for separation. The blood of the slain, the weeping voice of nature cries, 'TIS TIME TO PART. … there is something very absurd, in supposing a continent to be perpetually governed by an island.

On America's destiny

> Freedom hath been hunted round the globe. Asia, and Africa, have long expelled her—Europe regards her like a stranger, and England hath given her warning to depart. O! receive the fugitive, and prepare in time an asylum for mankind. … We have it in our power to begin the world over again. A situation, similar to the present, hath not happened since the days of Noah until now.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Fighting had begun at Lexington and Concord (April 1775), yet many colonists still hoped to reconcile with Britain and blamed Parliament rather than the king.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ordinary colonists, including farmers, artisans, and laborers; it was written in plain language to be read aloud in taverns and homes.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Thomas Paine, a recent English immigrant and radical, who had seen the British monarchy firsthand and believed all hereditary government was illegitimate.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice: Identify ONE specific piece of evidence from Common Sense and explain how it advanced the cause of independence. Page 1 APUSH Class Documents Class 4 - Common Sense
2. Why was Paine's plain, accessible style strategically important in 1776?
3. How does Paine's argument about monarchy connect to the Declaration of Independence six months later?

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> Paine's plain-language pamphlet made the case for independence and against monarchy, selling hundreds of thousands of copies and galvanizing ordinary colonists behind revolution.

Introduction

The cause of America is in a great measure the cause of all mankind.

[. . .]

Of the origin and design of government

Society in every state is a blessing, but government even in its best state is but a necessary evil; in its worst state an intolerable one; for when we suffer, or are exposed to the same miseries BY A GOVERNMENT, which we might expect in a country WITHOUT GOVERNMENT, our calamity is heightened by reflecting that we furnish the means by which we suffer. Government, like dress, is the badge of lost innocence; the palaces of kings are built on the ruins of the bowers of paradise. For were the impulses of conscience clear, uniform, and irresistibly obeyed, man would need no other lawgiver; but that not being the case, he finds it necessary to surrender up a part of his property to furnish means for the protection of the rest; and this he is induced to do by the same prudence which in every other case advises him out of two evils to choose the least.

[. . .]

On monarchy

There is something exceedingly ridiculous in the composition of monarchy; it first excludes a man from the means of information, yet empowers him to act in cases where the highest judgment is required. The state of a king shuts him from the world, yet the business of a king requires him to know it thoroughly; wherefore the different parts, by unnaturally opposing and destroying each other, prove the whole character to be absurd and useless. . . . One of the strongest NATURAL proofs of the folly of hereditary right in kings, is, that nature disapproves it, otherwise she would not so frequently turn it into ridicule by giving mankind an ASS FOR A LION.

[. . .]

Thoughts on the present state of American affairs

In the following pages I offer nothing more than simple facts, plain arguments, and common sense; and have no other Preliminaries to settle with the reader, than that he will divest himself of prejudice and prepossession, and suffer his reason and his feelings to determine for themselves; that he will put ON, or rather that he will not put OFF the true character of a man, and generously enlarge his views beyond the present day.

[. . .]

But Britain is the parent country, say some. Then the more shame upon her conduct. Even brutes do not devour their young, nor savages make war upon their families; wherefore the assertion, if true, turns to her reproach; but it happens not to be true, or only partly so and the phrase PARENT or MOTHER COUNTRY hath been jesuitically adopted by the king and his parasites, with a low papistical design of gaining an unfair bias on the credulous weakness of our minds. Europe, and not England, is the parent country of America. This new world hath been the asylum for the persecuted lovers of civil and

religious liberty from EVERY PART of Europe. Hither have they fled, not from the tender embraces of the mother, but from the cruelty of the monster; and it is so far true of England, that the same tyranny which drove the first emigrants from home, pursues their descendants still.

[. . .]

On reconciliation

Every thing that is right or natural pleads for separation. The blood of the slain, the weeping voice of nature cries, 'TIS TIME TO PART. Even the distance at which the Almighty hath placed England and America, is a strong and natural proof, that the authority of the one, over the other, was never the design of Heaven. . . . Small islands not capable of protecting themselves, are the proper objects for kingdoms to take under their care; but there is something very absurd, in supposing a continent to be perpetually governed by an island. In no instance hath nature made the satellite larger than its primary planet, and as England and America, with respect to each other, reverses the common order of nature, it is evident they belong to different systems; England to Europe, America to itself.

[. . .]

O ye that love mankind! Ye that dare oppose, not only the tyranny, but the tyrant, stand forth! Every spot of the old world is overrun with oppression. Freedom hath been hunted round the globe. Asia, and Africa, have long expelled her—Europe regards her like a stranger, and England hath given her warning to depart. O! receive the fugitive, and prepare in time an asylum for mankind.

[. . .]

On America's destiny

We have it in our power to begin the world over again. A situation, similar to the present, hath not happened since the days of Noah until now. The birthday of a new world is at hand, and a race of men, perhaps as numerous as all Europe contains, are to receive their portion of freedom from the event of a few months. The Reflexion is awful—and in this point of view, How trifling, how ridiculous, do the little, paltry cavillings, of a few weak or interested men appear, when weighed against the business of a world.

Words to know

necessary evil — something bad that must be accepted because it is needed

hereditary right — the claim to rule simply by being born into a royal family

prepossession — a prejudice or opinion formed in advance

jesuitically — craftily and deceptively (an anti-Catholic slur)

asylum — a safe place of refuge

satellite — a smaller body orbiting a larger one; here, a colony